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Local Government Funding Sources

Contact your local government for more information on the funding sources listed below.

Taxes

Greenways can be funded through sales tax revenues. One example of a community that is using sales tax dollars to fund bicycle and pedestrian facilities is Cobb County, Georgia, where citizens voted to implement a one percent local sales tax to provide funding for transportation projects. Over four years, Cobb County Department of Transportation will receive \$3.8 million of this sales tax revenue for bicycle improvements alone, to be used as a match for federal dollars. Another example is Oklahoma City, where voters approved a temporary \$0.01 sales tax, which generated millions of dollars for greenway acquisition and development.

Impact Fees

Impact fees are monetary one-time charges levied by a local government on new development. Unlike required dedications, impact fees can be applied to finance greenway facilities located outside the boundary of development. These fees can be levied through the subdivision or building permit process to finance greenways in Butler and Hamilton Counties.

Bond Referendums

Communities across the nation have successfully placed propositions on local ballots to support greenway development. The Charlotte-Mecklenburg County, North Carolina, area passed four consecutive referendums that generated more than \$3 million for greenways. Guilford County, North Carolina also passed a referendum that appropriated \$1.6 million for development of the Bicentennial Trail. Since bonds rely on the support of the voting population, an aggressive education and awareness program will need to be implemented prior to any referendum vote.

Capital Improvements Program

Some local governments have initiated a yearly appropriation for greenway and trail development in the capital improvements program. In Raleigh, North Carolina, greenways continue to be built and maintained, year after year, due to a dedicated source of annual funding that has ranged from \$100,000 to \$500,000, administered through the Parks and Recreation Department.

Private Sector Sources

Many communities have solicited greenway funding from a variety of private foundations, corporations, and other conservation-minded benefactors. As a general rule, local foundations and businesses will have a greater interest in and be more likely to fund local projects. These local sources should be approached first, before seeking funds outside the community.

Local Businesses

Local industries and private businesses may agree to provide support for development of

greenways through:

- Donations of cash to a specific greenway segment
- Donations of services by corporations to reduce the cost of the greenway
- Implementation, including equipment and labor to construct and install elements of a trail
- Donations in the cost of materials purchased from local businesses which support greenway implementation and can supply essential products for facility development.

This method of raising funds requires a great deal of staff coordination. One example of a successful endeavor of this type is the Swift Creek Recycled Greenway in Cary, North Carolina. A total of \$40,000 in donated construction materials and labor made this trail an award-winning demonstration project. (Some materials used in the "recycled trail" were considered waste materials by local industries!)

Trail Sponsors

A sponsorship program for trail amenities allows for smaller donations to be received both from individuals and businesses. The program must be well planned and organized, with design standards and associated costs established for each amenity. Project elements which may be funded can include wayside exhibits, benches, trash receptacles, entry signage, and picnic areas. Usually, plaques recognizing the individual contributors are placed on the constructed amenities or at a prominent entry point to the trail.

Volunteer Work

Community volunteers may help with trail construction, maintenance, fund raising and a whole host of other activities. Potential sources of volunteer labor in Butler and Hamilton Counties could include local bicyclists, local historical groups, neighborhood associations, local churches, conservation groups, school groups, and local civic clubs such as Kiwanis, Rotary and Lions Clubs.

A good example of a volunteer greenway program is Cheyenne, Wyoming, which generated an impressive amount of community support and volunteer work. The program has the unusual problem of having to insist that volunteers wait to begin landscaping trails until construction is completed. A manual for greenway volunteers was developed in 1994 to guide and regulate volunteer work. The manual includes a description of appropriate volunteer efforts, request forms, waiver and release forms, and a completion form (volunteers are asked to summarize their accomplishments). Written guidelines are also provided for volunteer work in 100-year floodplains.

To better organize volunteer activity, Cheyenne developed an "Adopt-a-Spot" program. Participants who adopt a segment of trail are responsible for periodic trash pick-up, but can also install landscaping, prune trail-side vegetation, develop wildlife enhancement projects, and install site amenities. All improvements must be consistent with the Greenway Development Plan and must be approved by the local Greenway Coordinator. Adopt-a-Spot volunteers are allowed to display their names on a small sign along the adopted section of greenway.

"Buy-a-Foot" Programs

"Buy-a-Foot" programs have been successful in raising funds and awareness for trail and greenway projects across the country. Under local initiatives, citizens are encouraged to purchase one linear foot of the greenway by donating the cost of construction. An excellent example of a successful endeavor is the High Point (North Carolina) Greenway "Buy-a-Foot" campaign, in which linear greenway "feet" were sold at a cost of \$25 per foot. Those who donated were given a greenway T-shirt and a certificate. This project provided an estimated \$5,000 in funds.

Developer Dedications

Cary, North Carolina, has used a dedication program to acquire land for its greenway program. Other communities have used such programs to build facilities, such as sidewalks, trails and other amenities, as part of new development. The developer typically fronts the cost of these improvements and passes the costs along to home buyers.

American Greenways DuPont Awards

The Conservation Fund's American Greenways Program has teamed with the DuPont Corporation and the National Geographic Society to award small grants (\$250 to \$2,000) to stimulate the planning, design and development of greenways. These grants can be used for activities such as mapping, conducting ecological assessments, surveying land, holding

conferences, developing brochures, producing interpretive displays, incorporating land trusts, building trails, and other creative projects. Grants cannot be used for academic research, institutional support, lobbying or political activities.

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